



Relook required: After his semifinal defeat against Alcaraz, Sinner will go back to the drawing board and undoubtedly make some tactical changes. GETTY IMAGES

tournament Down Under, and his highly regarded coach, Juan Carlos Ferrero, who underwent knee surgery in December, missed the year's opening major while rehabbing in Spain. As a result, Alcaraz's shot selection and confidence suffered.

He didn't fare any better in February when he played two clay events in South America, losing in the Buenos Aires semifinals and spraining his ankle in his first match at Rio de Janeiro. The lingering injury forced him to end his first practice at Indian Wells after 30 minutes. But during the trophy presentation, the youthful Spaniard said, "After every match, I was feeling better."

During the semifinals, Ferrero shouted advice and encouragement from the Player's Box as he matched tactical wits with another superb coach, Darren Cahill — who achieved renown by guiding Lleyton Hewitt, Andre Agassi, and Simona Halep to world No. 1 rankings — in Sinner's camp.

Cahill, nicknamed 'Killer' during his pro career, steadily developed the mild-mannered Sinner into an assassin on the court. Since he

joined Sinner's coaching team in July 2022, the lanky 6'3" Italian has added finesse to his previously one-dimensional power game, strengthened his second serve, and, most importantly, improved his athleticism and defence.

With a more complete game and smart tactics to implement it, Jannik captured seven titles and boosted his ranking from No. 10 to a career-high No. 3.

Alcaraz, despite winning two Grand Slam titles and becoming the youngest man at 19 in the Open Era to rank No. 1, is also an unfinished product. To beat Sinner, who won their last two matches and led 4-3 in their budding rivalry, he'd have to improve his tactics and control his emotions.

Slugging it out with Sinner proved to be a losing formula for Alcaraz. So Ferrero, the 2003 French Open champion, devised a new game plan. "Juan Carlos told me they've been doing drills where Carlos has to hit two looping topspin shots," said Tennis Channel analyst and former No. 1 Jim Courier. "Then he's allowed to play an aggressive shot and then go back to it [variety] and throw in a

slice. They're trying to program Carlos to be a little less risky because his instincts are all aggression all the time."

Alas, a nervous Alcaraz lost the plot in the first set. Sinner thrived in a baseline slugfest, winning twice as many points (28 to 14) and the set 6-1.

The tide turned in the second set when Alcaraz deployed a variety of smart tactics. The Spaniard retreated farther behind the baseline, a la Medvedev, to return Sinner's booming serve more consistently. He changed pace to disrupt Sinner's rhythm and to recover when he was out of position.

Like a boxer jabbing to set up knockout punches, Alcaraz put more balls in play and, when he saw an opening, attacked with explosive forehands. To keep Sinner off balance, he served and volleyed on occasion, and, of course, hit devilish drop shots.

Carlos broke serve for 3-1 with a volley winner set up by a 97-mph forehand. Serving for the second set, he saved a break point with a bold backhand winner that smacked the sideline and clinched it with a